3.1 Grant's Presidency

Think about how much has been at stake in recent presidential elections. The election of 1868 was similar, especially for Republicans and African Americans. A Democratic victory could deliver the end of Reconstruction.

MAIN IDEA After their party's victory in the 1868 presidential election, Republicans helped pass the 15th Amendment.





1868 Campaign Buttons Grant's running mate was Schuyler (SKY-ler) Colfax, a prominent Radical Republican. The candidates' campaign buttons feature ferrotypes, or photos printed on tin.

THE ELECTION OF GENERAL GRANT

In the 1868 presidential race, the Republicans nominated Ulysses S. Grant, the great Union hero of the Civil War. Although Grant had no experience in government, Republicans believed their candidate would be able to please members of both parties. When Grant accepted the nomination, he said, "Let us have peace." That phrase became a theme for the campaign. Republicans were aware that white voters had become less willing to help African Americans. As a result, the party did not promise to expand Reconstruction or to further promote the rights of African Americans.

The Democrats nominated **Horatio Seymour**, the former governor of New York, as their candidate. Seymour was part of a group of Democrats called the **Copperheads**. As you probably know, a copperhead is a poisonous snake. During the Civil War, this group, who called themselves "Peace Democrats," opposed emancipation and the draft. Republicans called the group "Copperheads" because they believed its members were Confederate sympathizers.

Seymour and the Copperheads relied on fear and racism to attract voters. Seymour criticized the Republicans for their aggressive handling of Reconstruction. He felt the government placed too much importance on African-American rights. His ideals appealed to many midwestern farmers who felt the Republicans did not understand their way of life. He also appealed to urban whites who believed free African Americans would move to the North and take their jobs.

Despite Seymour's rhetoric, or use of persuasive language, Grant led the Republicans to victory in the 1868 election. About 500,000 African Americans voted for Grant, helping him receive 53 percent of the ballots. In his inaugural speech, Grant declared, "I shall on all subjects have a policy to recommend, but none to enforce against the will of the people." He promised, unlike Andrew Johnson, to carry out the laws that Congress passed.

THE 15TH AMENDMENT

After the 1868 election, Republicans pushed for the adoption of the **15th Amendment** to the Constitution. Under the amendment's terms, the federal and state governments could not restrict the right to vote because of race, color, or

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CRITICAL VIEWING Called *The 15th Amendment*, this 1870 print illustrates a parade celebrating the amendment's passage. The large image is surrounded by portraits of those who helped pass the amendment, including Abraham Lincoln, and scenes depicting African-American life. What do some of the scenes illustrate?

previous condition of servitude—in other words, slavery. The amendment would complete the political reforms sought by Reconstruction. Congress approved the amendment in February 1869 despite Democratic opposition, and it became part of the Constitution in 1870.

The intent of the amendment was to limit the southern states' ability to prevent African Americans from participating in the political process. But the new law did little for African Americans outside the former Confederacy. It also did not restrict or change any of the laws that states had placed on the rights of males to vote, such as charging **poll taxes**. A poll tax is a fee charged when people register to vote. Meanwhile, the Amnesty Act of 1872 removed voting restrictions on most of those who had belonged to the Confederacy.

The adoption of the 13th, 14th, and 15th amendments fundamentally changed the nation by establishing citizenship rights and full equality for anyone born in the United States. However, over the next couple of decades, courts and political interests would undermine the intent of the amendments.

Still, rights and equality were not on the minds of most people in the 1870s. They wanted their elected leaders to pay more attention to problems closer to home, including a severe economic depression. As an Illinois newspaper observed, "the negro is now a voter and a citizen. Let him hereafter take his chances in the battle of life."

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the theme of Grant's presidential campaign?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** What differing views characterized the Republican and Democratic presidential candidates in the election of 1868?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why would a poll tax prevent African Americans from voting?

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